



Framework Companion Guide

Approach · **I**mplementation · **R**esponsibility · **E**nablement

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For educators, coaches, organizational leaders, and nonprofit founders doing the work of building learning communities that last.

A Note Before You Begin

This guide was not written to tell you what to think about artificial intelligence. It was written to give you a structured way to think about it yourself, in your context, with the people you actually serve.

The questions AI raises in educational organizations are not primarily technical questions. They are governance questions. Who decides which tools we use? What protects our students and the communities we serve? What does responsible adoption look like, not in the abstract, but in our building, our organization, and our work? Those questions do not come with a universal answer. They require a framework that helps you build the right answer for where you are.

That is what the AIRE™ Framework is. It emerged from direct work with educators, coaches, nonprofit founders, and organizational leaders who were navigating AI adoption without a shared structure or agreed-upon decision-making approach. The pattern that kept appearing was not a lack of good intentions. It was a lack of governance architecture beneath the intentions.

People are still doing good work despite a lack of resources, exposure, and systems of support that build capacity and create space for equitable learning and growth for students, parents, and education professionals.

The philosophy underneath this framework comes from a relatable place. A classroom with no lab. Students who had been pushed through a system despite not being prepared. A system that never went back to the beginning for them. A standardized examination that those students passed, then passed again, despite no one believing they could. What that classroom taught was this: the absence of a clear path is not the end of the story. It is the beginning of the problem worth solving.

That is the What If™ project.

AIRE™, a framework of the What If™ project, is what that question looks like applied to one of the most urgent challenges in education right now.

Artificial Intelligence. How might we use it ethically and efficiently?

This guide is a companion, not a compliance document. Work through it at the pace your organization needs. Return to it when the landscape changes. Share it with the people who need to be in the

conversation. The goal is not a perfect score. The goal is professional judgment that gets stronger every time you use it.

How to Use This Guide

Several patterns consistently emerge across organizations navigating AI adoption, regardless of size, sector, or resource level. The first is that **most organizations skip directly to implementation**. The pressure to do something feels more urgent than the work of deciding what to believe, so tools get deployed before governance structures exist to support them. The second pattern is that **when governance does happen, it tends to be reactive**. A policy written in response to a complaint. A training is scheduled in response to a question. A decision made under pressure rather than from a clear organizational stance. The third pattern is that **professional development about AI is almost universally treated as an event rather than an infrastructure**.

The AIRE™ Framework is organized specifically to interrupt those patterns. Four stages, in a deliberate sequence: Approach, Implementation, Responsibility, Enablement. Each stage represents a distinct set of questions that need to be answered before the next stage is sustainable. You can enter the framework wherever your most urgent need is. But the sequence exists for a reason, and understanding it helps you see why the stage you skipped is probably the source of the problem you are currently trying to solve.

This guide walks through each stage the same way.

Here is what the stage is asking of you.

Here are the specific questions it surfaces.

Here is what it looks like when this stage is underdeveloped.

Here is what to do about it.

The G.A.P. Assessment™ works alongside this guide as the diagnostic tool. It maps your organization's readiness across all four stages and tells you not just where the gaps are, but what kind of gap each one is, because a missing goal requires a different response than a missing policy.

Who This Guide Is Written For

This guide is written for anyone whose work involves building, leading, supporting, or sustaining a learning community. The framework does not require a specific title to be useful. It requires that you are responsible for some part of how learning happens in your organization and that you are trying to do that work well in a landscape that AI has changed.

If you are an educator or instructional coach, this guide gives you the governance context behind the AI decisions you are already making, and a framework for making them more deliberately. You do not need to wait for a policy to start practicing professional judgment.

If you are a school or organizational leader, this guide gives you the architecture for building AI governance that is efficient, defensible, equitable, and not dependent on any single person to sustain it. The stages map what needs to be in place before the next layer of work is meaningful.

If you are a nonprofit founder or executive director, this guide acknowledges that your governance context is different from a district's. You may not have a board policy or a district IT team. You have a mission, a community, and a responsibility to the people you serve that does not diminish because your organization is smaller. The framework applies to you entirely.

If you lead a team that supports educational organizations, this guide gives you a shared language and a diagnostic structure you can bring to the organizations you partner with. What you model is what gets adopted. The AIRE™ Framework gives you something worth modeling.

What all of these roles share is this: you are trying to do right by the people your organization serves, in conditions that are changing faster than the support structures around you. That is exactly who this framework was built for.

About the AIRE™ Framework

The AIRE™ Framework is a governance architecture for responsible AI adoption in educational organizations. *Three things it is not:* a technology training program, a set of policies to copy and paste, and a one-time exercise. It is a structured way of thinking through the decisions that AI adoption requires, in the order those decisions need to be made, with a diagnostic tool that tells you where you are and the next steps that tell you what to do about it.

Most AI professional development in education focuses on tools. Here is the platform. Here is how to prompt it. Here is the feature that saves you time. That training has real value. But it does not answer the questions that determine whether AI adoption in your organization is responsible, equitable, and sustainable. Those are governance questions. And most organizations are trying to answer them without a governance framework.

Several patterns emerge when governance is missing. Adoption happens informally, driven by whoever is most enthusiastic rather than by shared decision-making. Data privacy exposure accumulates in ways leadership cannot see. Professional development peaks at launch and regresses because the infrastructure to sustain it was never built. Equity gaps widen rather than close because tools and training designed for everyone in practice serve the people who already have the most.

The Four Stages at a Glance

Stage	The Core Question	What Is at Stake Without It
A Approach	Why are we adopting AI, and what values will guide every decision that follows?	Every subsequent decision gets made in a values vacuum. Drift is not a risk. It is a certainty.
I Implementation	Which tools are we actually using, who approved them, and how are we monitoring what is happening?	Adoption gets driven by early adopters and individual preferences. Inconsistency compounds invisibly.
R Responsibility	What ethical, legal, and professional guardrails protect the people we serve?	Legal and ethical exposure accumulates. By the time it becomes visible, it is already significant.
E Enablement	What capacity, culture, and ongoing support will sustain this work beyond the launch?	Professional development becomes an event. Adoption peaks and

		regresses. The gap between intent and practice widens.
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The stages build on each other. A clear Approach makes Implementation more coherent. Structured Implementation makes Responsibility more specific. Robust Responsibility makes Enablement more credible. And Enablement, done well, feeds back into a stronger Approach over time. The AIRE™ Framework is only as strong as its least developed stage. That is not a warning. That is where you start.

Approach

Why and how your organization has chosen to engage with AI.

Before a single tool gets deployed, before training is scheduled, before any policy is drafted, there is a more fundamental question that needs an honest answer: why are you here? What does your organization actually believe about AI? Not what sounds good in a statement. What is true, and what does it mean for the students, families, and communities you are accountable to?

That is what the Approach stage asks. It is where you name your stance. Not a marketing statement and not a reactionary policy written in response to a parent complaint or a board question. A genuine, values-grounded articulation of why your organization is engaging with AI, what principles will guide every decision that follows, and what responsible adoption looks like in your specific context with your specific community. What If™ is the question underneath all of it.

Most organizations skip this. The pressure to do something feels more urgent than the work of deciding what to believe. That urgency is understandable. It is also the source of most of the governance problems that surface later, because decisions made without a guiding Approach have no center of gravity. They move toward whatever is most convenient in the moment rather than whatever is most aligned with your mission and your values. You end up having to defend decisions that were never actually made. They just happened.

What the Approach Stage Is Asking You

- What is our organizational stance on AI? Have we named it explicitly, or are we operating on assumptions that different people on our team interpret differently?
- How does our AI Approach connect to our mission and our equity commitments? If there is tension between AI adoption and the values we say we hold, have we named and addressed that tension honestly?
- What does responsible AI adoption look like in our specific context, with our specific community? Not in general. Here. With these people.
- Who owns our Approach? Who is responsible for keeping it current as the landscape changes, and how will we make sure everyone on our team knows what it says?

The Approach Statement

The primary deliverable of this stage is a written Approach Statement. One to three paragraphs. It answers three questions: why your organization is adopting AI, what values will govern that adoption, and what responsible use looks like in your context. It is not a legal document. It is not a policy. It is the statement that every other AI governance decision in your organization should be able to point back to.

A strong Approach Statement is specific enough to be useful. It names the populations you serve. It connects to your existing equity commitments rather than treating AI governance as a separate track. It is written in language that a teacher, a parent, a board member, and a community partner can all read and understand. And it is owned by a named person who is responsible for keeping it current.

One pattern to watch: an Approach Statement that lives in a document no one references is not yet an Approach. It becomes one when it is communicated to your full team, when it gets cited in AI-related decisions, and when it gets revisited as the landscape changes. The statement is the starting point, not the destination.

If your team cannot tell you in one sentence what your organization's stance on AI is, you have a goals gap in this stage. That is your starting point. Not a policy. Not a training. A conversation that ends with a written answer to the question: why AI, which values, what responsible looks like here.

Approach × GAP Assessment™: What the Assessment Reveals

Approach × Goals: Organizational AI Vision

If your score is below 3: Purposeless Adoption

Implementation is happening without a governing vision. Every decision that follows will drift without something to point back to.

1. Schedule a 60-minute leadership conversation using the AIRE™ Stance Worksheet. Not a meeting. A conversation with a written outcome.
2. Draft one paragraph: why AI, which values, what responsible looks like in your context. Share it with your team before finalizing.
3. Connect your AI Approach explicitly to your equity commitments. If you cannot draw that line, the Approach is not yet complete.

Approach × Actions: Establishing Your Stance

If your score is below 3: Unactivated Vision

The intent may exist but it has not moved into practice. A belief that has not been communicated to your team is not yet a stance.

1. Schedule and document a formal leadership conversation about your AI posture this month. Put a date on it.
2. Communicate your Approach Statement to all staff in a format you can track. An email is not sufficient on its own.

3. Assign one named person who is responsible for keeping the Approach Statement current. Not a committee. One person.

Approach × Parameters: Boundaries for AI Adoption

If your score is below 3: Ungoverned Space

Without defined parameters, people on your team make individual judgment calls in a vacuum. Risk accumulates in ways you cannot see.

1. Distribute the AI Use Decision Checklist to your full team as an immediate guardrail while you build the larger structure.
2. Draft a one-page Acceptable and Prohibited Use framework within 30 days. It does not have to be perfect. It has to exist.
3. Name one person your team can contact with AI questions before they act. That contact point closes a significant gap immediately.

Implementation

How AI tools and workflows are being deployed and monitored.

Implementation is where intention meets infrastructure. You have named your Approach. Now you need to answer a different set of questions: which tools is your organization actually using, who approved them, what agreements govern your data, how are you monitoring what is happening across your team, and what is the process when something goes wrong?

Here is the pattern that shows up most consistently at this stage. The visible activity of AI adoption is happening. Staff are using tools. Workflows are being built. But underneath that activity, invisible risk is accumulating. A staff member finds a tool that saves three hours on a Sunday night and starts using it without approval. A coach uses a free AI platform to prepare for observation debriefs. A program director uses a consumer AI product to draft policy documents. None of these decisions are inherently wrong. All of them carry governance implications the organization may not know exist.

Structured Implementation means AI tool adoption follows a defined process rather than individual preference. It means there is a published approved tool list that people on your team can reference. It means data privacy agreements exist for every tool in active use. It means there is a feedback mechanism for your team to surface concerns, and someone is monitoring what is actually happening so you are not the last to find out when something goes sideways.

What the Implementation Stage Is Asking You

- What AI tools are currently in use across our organization? Do we have a signed data privacy agreement for each one?
- Do we have a published approved tool list? Does everyone on our team know where to find it and how to request that a new tool be added?
- What does our deployment process look like? Is there a defined pathway for evaluating, piloting, and rolling out new tools, or is adoption happening informally?
- Who monitors AI tool use across our organization? How does that person surface what they find to leadership?
- What is our 30-day implementation milestone, and who owns it?

Shadow AI: The Gap You Cannot See

Shadow AI is the term for AI tools being used within an organization without organizational awareness or approval. It is the most common Implementation gap right now across educational organizations of every size and type, and it is largely invisible to leadership until something goes wrong.

A teacher using an unapproved tool to generate parent communications. A coach using a free AI platform to process observation notes. A nonprofit program director using a consumer AI product to draft grant language that includes references to the communities they serve. Each of these uses may be well-intentioned. Each creates liability the organization does not know it has. And in each case, the person making the decision did not make it carelessly. They made it in a vacuum because the governance structure they needed did not exist yet.

The approved tool standard is not about restricting what people on your team can do. It is about ensuring that when a tool is used in a professional context, your organization has made a conscious decision about whether it is appropriate, whether its data practices are consistent with legal requirements, and whether staff have what they need to use it responsibly. Publishing an approved list, even a short one, closes the vacuum that shadow AI fills.

If you do not have a published approved tool list, that is your first Implementation action. It does not have to be comprehensive on day one. Even a list of five tools with clear data privacy agreement status closes the vacuum and gives your team something to reference. An incomplete list is infinitely better than no list.

Implementation * GAP Assessment™: What the Assessment Reveals

Implementation * Goals: Deployment Outcomes

If your score is below 3: Unmeasured Rollout

Deployment is happening without a destination. You cannot assess progress or identify what is working because no one has defined what success looks like.

1. Define what success looks like for AI implementation in your organization, specifically and by role. Not in general.
2. Set a 90-day milestone with a named owner and a formal review checkpoint already on the calendar.
3. Build a simple way for leadership to see adoption progress by role so you are not relying on word of mouth.

Implementation * Actions: Structured Deployment

If your score is below 3: Reactive Implementation

Adoption is being driven by whoever is most enthusiastic rather than by a structure everyone can follow. Inconsistency compounds and the gap between early adopters and everyone else widens.

1. Design a 30-day pilot structure for any new tool before organization-wide deployment. Test before you scale.
2. Create a simple feedback form your team can use to surface AI-related concerns. Make it easy and make it safe.
3. Schedule a 30-day implementation review with a named facilitator. Put it on the calendar before you need it.

Implementation x Parameters: Approved Tools and Oversight

If your score is below 3: Shadow AI Vacuum

Without a published approved list, your team fills the gap with personal tools and individual judgment. Shadow AI becomes the de facto policy by default.

1. Publish a current approved tool list this week. Even a short one closes the vacuum and gives your team somewhere to go.
2. Assign one person responsible for identifying unapproved tool use and reviewing it with leadership quarterly.
3. Create a process for your team to request tool additions. Shadow adoption needs a sanctioned alternative, not just a rule against it.

Responsibility

The ethical, legal, and professional guardrails that protect the people you serve.

Responsibility is the governance layer that makes AI adoption defensible. It is the stage where you answer the questions that determine whether what you are doing can withstand scrutiny. From a parent. From a student. From a community partner. From a regulator. From a community that has historical reasons to be cautious about institutions that move fast with new technology.

This stage is not about fear. It is about professionalism. Every educator and organizational leader makes professional judgments every day about what is appropriate in their context, what serves the people they are accountable to, and what they can explain if asked. The Responsibility stage gives those judgments a framework. It names the standards. It provides the tools. It makes the habit of asking the right questions before acting something embedded in your professional culture rather than left to individual discretion.

Three core elements define this stage: data privacy, acceptable and prohibited use, and the daily habits of professional practice that keep adoption responsible over time. These elements are interdependent. A strong data privacy posture without a clear acceptable use policy leaves gaps. An acceptable use policy without training to embed it in daily practice is a document no one references when it matters. All three are required.

Data Privacy in an AI Context

What many people do not realize is that AI use can trigger data privacy obligations in ways that are not immediately obvious. Describing a student's learning needs, behavioral patterns, or academic performance in an AI prompt may constitute sharing protected information, even if the student's name does not appear. The specificity of the description, combined with other identifying details, can make a student identifiable. The same is true for staff, families, and community members.

Every AI tool that handles any information related to students, staff, or the communities you serve needs a signed data privacy agreement before it is used in a professional context. That agreement should be reviewed, not simply signed. It should be consistent with your organization's data governance policies and with the legal requirements of your state. And it should be revisited when the tool's terms of service change, which happens regularly and often without notification.

For nonprofit organizations and smaller educational organizations, this can feel overwhelming because the infrastructure for managing data privacy agreements is often not yet built. The right response to that feeling is not to proceed without the agreement. It is to name the gap, build the infrastructure, and treat the absence of a signed agreement as the stop sign it is.

The AI Use Decision Checklist

The AI Use Decision Checklist is a five-item professional tool designed to be worked through before an AI tool is used in any situation where the stakes include student data, family relationships, community trust, or organizational credibility. It is not a gate. It is a practice. Here are the five items and what each one is asking:

- 1. Student or Staff Data** Does this use involve personally identifiable information? If yes, verify that a signed data privacy agreement exists for this tool and that this specific use is consistent with that agreement. A name not appearing in the prompt does not automatically mean no protected information is present.
- 2. Approved Tool** Has this tool been approved for use by your organization? If not, stop and find out before proceeding. Using an unapproved tool is not a minor procedural issue. It creates liability your organization does not know it has.
- 3. Output Review** Is this AI output being treated as a draft that requires professional review before it reaches students, families, colleagues, or communities? A quick read is not a review. Review means checking for accuracy, checking for context, and making sure the output fits the specific people it will serve.
- 4. Equity and Approach Alignment** Does this use reflect your equity commitments and AI Approach? Could it disadvantage any group of people you serve? This question applies in every organizational context, not only in high-need settings.
- 5. Defensibility** Could you explain and defend this AI use decision to a student, a family member, a community partner, or a supervisor? If imagining that conversation makes you uncomfortable, the discomfort is information. Use it.

The checklist is most effective when it is embedded in onboarding, referenced in coaching conversations, and returned to when new use cases arise. Professional judgment improves with practice. The checklist is the practice structure that makes that improvement possible.

Organizations that skip the Responsibility stage tend to build things that work until they do not. The checklist is not the whole of Responsibility, but it is the daily practice that keeps the rest of it alive between policy reviews and training sessions.

Responsibility x GAP Assessment™: What the Assessment Reveals

Responsibility x Goals: Ethics and Privacy Priorities

If your score is below 3: Implicit Responsibility

When responsibility is assumed rather than named, it is the first thing that erodes under pressure. Implicit standards cannot be communicated, enforced, or defended.

1. Name data privacy as a strategic AI governance priority in your Approach Statement. Not implied. Named.
2. Write one sentence that connects your equity commitments to your AI decision-making standard. If you cannot write it, that is the gap.
3. Identify who on your leadership team owns Responsibility governance and communicate that ownership to your full team.

Responsibility x Actions: Training and Checklist Use

If your score is below 3: Policy Without Practice

Governance documents exist but are not embedded in daily decisions. The gap between policy and practice is where exposure accumulates.

1. Conduct a training session on what personally identifiable information looks like in AI prompts with every member of your team within 30 days.
2. Facilitate a Decision Checklist walkthrough with each role group in your organization. An all-staff email is not sufficient.
3. Build the Checklist into your onboarding process so new team members arrive with the habit, not just the document.

Responsibility x Parameters: Agreements and Policies

If your score is below 3: Legal Exposure

Operating without signed data privacy agreements and a published use policy creates exposure that scales with every tool you deploy and every use case you add.

1. Audit every tool currently in use. Any tool without a signed data privacy agreement should be paused immediately, regardless of how useful it is.
2. Draft or adopt an Acceptable and Prohibited Use policy within 30 days. It does not have to be long. It has to be clear.
3. Schedule an annual policy review and assign someone to track data privacy agreement renewal dates before tools are used past their agreement period.

Enablement

The capacity, culture, and support structures that sustain responsible AI adoption over time.

Enablement is the stage that determines whether everything built in the first three stages survives beyond the initial launch. It is the answer to the question every organization eventually faces: what happens after the professional development session ends, the presenter leaves, and people return to their classrooms, offices, and programs to figure out what any of this means on a regular Tuesday?

In most organizations, the answer is regression. Not because the learning did not happen. Because the infrastructure to sustain it was never built. Enablement is that infrastructure. It is the capacity your team has to use AI tools responsibly, the culture that makes responsible use the norm rather than the exception, and the support structures that ensure professional learning is continuous rather than episodic.

A pattern worth naming here: when professional development is generic, it benefits the people who already have the most capacity. Educators and coaches who are already comfortable with technology will get more from an all-staff AI session than those who are not. Team members with strong foundations in their practice will apply new tools more effectively than those still building those foundations. Enablement that does not account for these differences will widen the gap it is supposed to close. Role-specific, ongoing, relationship-based professional learning is not a luxury in this stage. It is the difference between adoption that sticks and adoption that does not.

What the Enablement Stage Is Asking You

- What does AI-capable look like for each role in our organization? Have we defined proficiency specifically enough that people on our team know what they are working toward?
- Who is the named AI point-of-contact in our organization? Does every member of our team know who that person is and how to reach them without fear of judgment?
- What does our ongoing professional learning infrastructure look like? Are we relying on annual events, or have we built something people can return to between sessions?
- How do we recognize responsible AI adoption in our organization? Is recognition specific and meaningful, or is it generic enough to be meaningless?

- Are we tracking whether our Enablement efforts are changing practice, or only whether they are being delivered?

From Training to Culture

The difference between training and culture is sustainability. Training is something that happens to people. Culture is something people participate in building and maintaining. An organization that has built a culture of responsible AI adoption is one where people ask the right questions before acting, not because they were told to, but because asking those questions is what it means to be a professional in this organization.

Several things are required to build that culture. Leaders have to model the behaviors they are asking their teams to develop. Responsible AI use has to be recognized in ways specific enough to mean something. People need genuine access to support, not just a policy document and an email address. And the organization needs to revisit and update its Enablement approach as the AI landscape changes, which it will, continuously.

One more pattern worth naming. The organizations that sustain AI adoption best are the ones that treat Enablement as a relationship, not a rollout. The people on your team who are most hesitant are often the people with the most important questions. Building a culture where those questions are welcome is what makes the difference between adoption that is wide and adoption that is deep.

Enablement is a culture, not an event. An organization that treats professional learning as a one-time launch will find that adoption peaks and then regresses without exception. The infrastructure that prevents regression is not another session. It is a living support structure that people can return to between sessions, and a culture that makes returning to it feel normal.

Enablement × GAP Assessment™: What the Assessment Reveals

Enablement × Goals: Defined Staff AI Capacity

If your score is below 3: Training Without Destination

Professional development is happening but people on your team cannot tell you what success looks like. Effort without a target dissipates. Momentum without direction is not progress.

1. Define AI capacity goals for each role in your organization separately. Educator goals, coach goals, and leadership goals are different.
2. Communicate those goals explicitly to your team alongside the rationale for each. People need to know not just what they are working toward but why it matters.
3. Build a simple self-assessment your team can use to track their own progress between formal check-ins.

Enablement × Actions: Role-Specific Support

If your score is below 3: Generic Enablement

All-staff sessions produce awareness. Role-specific sessions produce practice change. One-size professional development underserves every role it is supposed to serve.

1. Replace your next all-staff AI session with three 20-minute role-specific conversations. Smaller and targeted beats large and generic.
2. Assign and announce a named AI point-of-contact this week. One person. Announced. Accessible.
3. Identify two or three people on your team already practicing responsible AI use and ask them to model it for peers. Peer modeling is more durable than presenter-led training.

Enablement × Parameters: Sustained Support Structures

If your score is below 3: Unsustained Adoption

Without infrastructure for ongoing support, adoption peaks at launch and regresses. Every organization that treats Enablement as an event experiences this. It is not a personnel problem. It is a structural one.

1. Create a living AI resource hub your team can access between sessions. Not a folder of documents. A resource that gets updated.
2. Build a recognition mechanism for responsible AI use that is specific enough to be meaningful. Generic praise does not build culture.
3. Schedule quarterly Enablement check-ins and put them on the calendar now. Annual professional development is not a support structure.

The AIRE™ GAP Assessment™

The GAP Assessment™ is the diagnostic tool that maps your organization's current AI governance readiness across all four AIRE™ stages. GAP stands for Goals, Actions, and Parameters. These three dimensions represent the three things every organization needs at each stage of AI adoption: a clear destination, active movement toward it, and the structures that make the movement defensible.

The assessment produces a 12-cell matrix. Four AIRE™ stages on one axis, three GAP dimensions on the other. Each cell contains two rating statements you score on a one to four scale. A score of one means this does not yet exist in any meaningful form. A score of four means it is formalized, communicated, and embedded in practice in a way that does not depend on any single person to sustain it. That distinction, between what exists and what is embedded, is where most organizations find their real gaps.

The Three GAP Dimensions

G Goals *Where you are going.*

A low Goals score means your organization is working without a clear destination in this stage of adoption. Effort and resources are being spent without a shared definition of what success looks like. The work may feel productive without being purposeful. That distinction matters more than it appears.

A Actions *What you are doing.*

A low Actions score means your organization has intent but not momentum. There may be agreement on direction, but the specific behaviors, practices, and steps that would move things forward are not yet consistently happening. Goals without actions are intentions. Intentions without actions are not plans.

P Parameters *What governs the work.*

A low Parameters score means your organization is moving without guardrails. Adoption may be happening, but the structures, policies, and agreements that make it defensible and sustainable are not yet in place. Movement without parameters creates exposure. The exposure accumulates invisibly until it does not.

How to Read Your Scores

Score Range	Gap Level and What It Means for Your Work
1.0 – 2.0	Critical Gap. This area does not yet exist in any meaningful form. It needs immediate attention before other work in this stage can be sustained.
2.1 – 2.75	Developing. Early awareness and some activity exists but nothing is formalized or consistently practiced. A defined plan is needed within 30 days.
2.76 – 3.5	Building. Work is underway and something exists, but it is not yet complete, consistent, or embedded. Focus on formalizing and communicating what you have.
3.51 – 4.0	Strong. This area is formalized, communicated, and embedded in practice. Maintain it and use it as a model for the areas that are not yet here.

Your lowest-scoring cells are your highest-priority starting points. Not the ones that concern you most conceptually. The ones with the lowest scores. The next steps in each cell of the assessment are written for that specific gap. Start with your three lowest cells. Everything else follows from that.

Your Next Steps

The AIRE™ Framework is not a one-time exercise. It is a governance architecture that your organization will return to as your AI adoption matures, as tools change, and as the communities you serve ask new questions. What follows is a suggested sequence for getting started. The right starting point, though, is wherever your most urgent need actually is.

Step 1 Complete the GAP Assessment™.

Work through all twelve cells honestly. Rate where your organization is right now, not where you intend to be or where you were last year. The GAP Assessment™ is only useful if the scores reflect reality. If you can, bring others into the conversation. A single person's ratings are a starting point. Multiple perspectives produce a more accurate picture, and the conversation itself surfaces things the ratings alone will not.

Step 2 Name your three priority gaps.

Your three lowest-scoring cells are your starting points. For each one, name the stage, the GAP dimension, the score, and one sentence about what this gap costs your organization right now. Not in theory. In practice, with the people you serve. Specificity is what turns a priority gap into a real commitment rather than an item on a list.

Step 3 Build your 30-day plan.

For each priority gap, identify one specific action you can take within 30 days. Not a committee and not a planning process. One action with a named owner and a date. The AIRE™ Putting It All Together document provides a structured template for building this plan, including an AI prompt that lets you use AI itself as your thought partner in developing it.

Step 4 Return to the assessment in 90 days.

Re-rate your priority cells after 90 days of deliberate work. If the scores have moved, that is evidence of progress. If they have not, that is information about what the plan needs to change. The GAP Assessment™ is designed to be revisited, not completed once and set aside. It is a labyrinth, not a checklist.

Step 5 Expand the conversation.

AI governance is not a solo project. The AIRE™ Framework is most effective when it becomes a shared reference across your team and your organization. The Scenario Challenge is designed to bring educators, coaches, organizational leaders, and nonprofit teams into the same conversation, with scenarios differentiated by role and context so that everyone in the room can find themselves in at least one of them. Use it to build a common language before you need to make a common decision.

Every organization working on AI adoption has gaps. Every one. This framework does not exist to expose failure. It exists to name gaps precisely so the work of closing them can begin with clarity rather than anxiety. The goal is not a perfect score. The goal is professional judgment that improves every time you use it.

The absence of a clear path is not the end of the story.

It is the beginning of the problem worth solving.

A framework and prototype web app for guiding inclusive technology adoption in any organization, from evaluation to recommendation.

AIRE turns technology adoption into a shared, structured, and inclusive process. Deciding whether and how to adopt a tool shouldn't fall only to the technical experts in the room.

<https://aire-method.vercel.app/>

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